

Heating failure in cold weather

HOME BUILDING / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Use dry layers, blankets and a smaller dry room while you identify safe heat or a warmer reachable place. Never use a gas oven, barbecue or generator to heat indoors. Confusion, slurred speech, unusual drowsiness or poor coordination can mean hypothermia: seek urgent care and begin safe warming.

Do now.

- ☐ **Get dry and insulated**
01 Replace wet clothes, layer loose dry clothing and insulate beneath the body as well as above it. Keep vulnerable people away from draughts.
- ☐ **Use one workable space**
02 Choose a dry room that remains safe and has a usable exit. Close unnecessary interior doors without blocking ventilation needed by approved heating appliances.
- ☐ **Avoid combustion shortcuts**
03 Use only heating equipment approved for indoor use according to its instructions, with working CO alarms. A grill, oven or indoor generator is not a backup heater.
- ☐ **Check people regularly**
04 Cold can impair judgement. Pay particular attention to infants, older people and anyone with illness or limited mobility. Do not rely on a person saying they feel fine.
- ☐ **Move before severe exposure**
05 Confirm a warmer destination and safe route while people can still travel. Do not cross dangerous ice or an active hazard merely to reach a public warming centre.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Use the safest dry shelter and insulation available while confirming a warmer private or community destination. Leave early if you cannot keep vulnerable people warm rather than waiting for official shelter.

Watch for.

Do not give alcohol as a warming method or rub frostbitten skin. Fuel-burning devices can create lethal CO even when you cannot smell anything.

People & practical needs.

Assign a trusted adult to each person who needs assistance. Keep medicines, essential contacts and a workable reunion plan with the group

Next decision.

Contact a qualified repair provider when reachable and safe. Plan for medication storage, food, water and sanitation during a longer outage; a portable heater alone does not solve all needs.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

Extreme cold · official guidance

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/heating-failure/>